

Kale

CULTIVARS

- Scarlet
- Ripbor

INTENSIVE SPACING

- 2 rows per bed spaced every 18" (45 cm) on the row

FERTILIZATION

- Kale will stay a long time in the ground and therefore is amended with lots of compost, fresh or aged. Rule of thumb is to spread +/- 1 inch (5 cm) all across the bed. When the biological activity is not optimal (in cold or poor soils), add extra amendments of organic fertilisers like alfalfa meal (2-0-2) and/or pelleted chicken manure (5-3-2).

IMPLANTATION

We plan for 3 kale planting in the season, and intend to harvest the plants over 14 weeks. This ensures continuous supply of new leaves harvested every week. Kale is usually planted alongside Swiss Chard, a crop with almost identical management strategies.

EQUIPMENT

- Rotary harrow
- Broadfork
- 30" bed prep rake
- Popping tray
- Landscape fabric, staples, drip tape and fittings.

TRANSPLANT ITINERARY

- Pass through beds with the broadfork.
- Remove large debris from the bed if needed (use flail mower, rake or manually remove the large chunks).
- Apply compost and/or amendments across the bed and pass with the rotary harrow at a depth of 2.5" (6 cm). Since the bed is covered with landscape fabric, it doesn't need to be cleaned up with another pass of the rake.
- If installing drip tape, set out 4 lines per bed and start the system. Fix any leaks you find at that point.
- Lay down landscape fabric and secure it with landscape staples each second step (5' or 1.5 m). It needs to be really tight.
- Use the popping tray to facilitate extraction and transplant the kale seedlings. Do not bury the plug (top should be even with soil level) and make sure to place them in the center of each hole. 1 person / 100'bed is a good ratio for efficient workflow.
- Water the bed thoroughly the first time, keeping the soil moist for the first week after transplant.

WEEDING

- No weeding required

PLANT PROTECTION

- If problematic, control flea beetles by covering with anti-insect netting and mini-tunnels so the netting covers the 2 beds.
- Kale and Swiss Chard will benefit from bi-monthly doses of boron and seaweed (or compost tea) applied foliarly. Plan to apply at the same time as spraying fresh beets.

HARVEST

- Harvesting is done by snapping off 2 to 3 leaves per plant, each leaf measuring between 6" and 9" (15-20 cm). Leave the smaller leaves at the top of the plant and any dead or yellow leaves on the bottom.

- Make bouquets of 5-6 leaves, wrapping an elastic band twice around the stems and making piles of 5 in the aisles.
- 1 person should harvest between +/- 100 bunches per hour.

CONDITIONING

- Kale is not always washed, but should be if harvested on hot days, in order to remove field heat.
- Dunk plants in cold water, leave to dry for a few minutes and place criss-cross in storage bins. Identify the bins.

STORING

- Kale is stored in a cold room kept at 35°F (2°C) and should not be stored for longer than 4 days before being sold.